NORTH CURRENT
Fact-check column, May 2026

Owen Brandt
(612) 555-0183
owen.brandt.writes@gmail.com

Slug: FACTCHECK MISSISSIPPI

Head: # Fact check: Is the Mississippi America's dirtiest river?

Dek: *The ranking behind a viral graphic adds up pounds of chemicals discharged, not how polluted the water is. By that math, the biggest river wins.*

Rating: **Misleading**

By Owen Brandt
Filed May 20, 2026
About 490 words, plus sources

The claim: A graphic calling the Mississippi "America's dirtiest river" is making the rounds again. It has circulated online for years, and a city council candidate shared it this month.

Where it comes from: The graphic traces back to a 2014 ranking by an environmental advocacy group. The group used the Toxics Release Inventory, the Environmental Protection Agency database in which industrial plants report the chemicals they release, and added up the pounds that permitted facilities discharged into each waterway in a single year. Most of those discharges are legal, made under Clean Water Act permits. The Mississippi came out number one. The graphic keeps the ranking and drops the context.

What it measures: Size, mostly. The ranking counts total pounds, not concentration, which is how much of a substance is in a given amount of water. The Mississippi and its tributaries drain all or part of 31 states, about 40 percent of the lower 48, and the river carries more water than any other in the country. It also runs past more cities, factories and power plants than almost any other U.S. river. Add up the pounds from all of them, and a river that size will land at or near the top of the list almost by default.

Dilution matters, too. Ten pounds of a chemical can foul a trout stream. In a river moving as much water as the Mississippi does by the time it reaches Red Wing, the same 10 pounds is spread through vastly more water.

The inventory also leaves out much of what ails the river. It tracks releases from industrial facilities. Runoff from farm fields and city streets, which carries much of the river's sediment and nutrients, isn't in it at all. A pounds ranking built on the EPA numbers says nothing about what is actually in the water at Hidden Falls or Red Wing.

What the monitoring shows: The Minnesota Pollution Control Agency's assessments of the river through the Twin Cities find it meeting most water-quality standards most of the time. The real trouble is sediment and nutrients. Phosphorus and nitrate washing off farm fields upstream, much of it delivered by the Minnesota River, feed algae blooms in Lake Pepin and add to the low-oxygen dead zone in the Gulf of Mexico. Sediment clouds the water and is filling the upper end of Lake Pepin far faster than it did before settlement.

The river isn't spotless. The state still advises limits on eating some fish caught in the metro stretch, mainly because of mercury and PFAS, the so-called forever chemicals. Those warnings come from testing fish, not from adding up permits.

Rating: Misleading. The number behind the graphic is real, but it ranks size and permitted load, not how dirty the water is. The Mississippi has serious pollution problems. The worst are sediment and nutrients washing in from the land around it. Being the biggest river on a pounds list is not one of them.

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SOURCES

1. U.S. Environmental Protection Agency, Toxics Release Inventory: surface-water discharge data, reporting years 2012 to 2014.
2. The 2014 advocacy report the graphic is drawn from.
3. Minnesota Pollution Control Agency: water-quality assessment of the Mississippi River, Twin Cities reach.
4. Minnesota Department of Health: fish consumption guidance for the Mississippi River in the metro area.
5. Background interview with a university hydrologist, May 15.